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THE INVISIBLE BRUISE

Surviving emotional abuse, suffering in silence, and rewriting your life.

BY MK PARRISH · \$22

INTRO: THE BRUISE NO ONE CAN SEE

If someone hits you, there's a mark. People understand a mark. They bring you ice, they ask who did it, they believe you because the evidence is right there on your skin.

Emotional abuse leaves no mark. That's the whole problem. You walk around carrying an injury that doesn't show up in any mirror, and you start to wonder if you imagined the whole thing. You didn't.

This book is for the person who can't quite name what happened to her. Who keeps saying *it wasn't that bad* while flinching at her own phone. Who has gotten very, very good at being fine.

I'm not going to tell you it gets better in the way people mean when they want you to stop talking. I'm going to tell you the truth: you were hurt, the hurt was real, and you get to rebuild the person who was standing there before all of it started.

“

You are not too sensitive. You were trained to doubt your own senses. There's a difference, and learning it is where you begin.

Read this slowly. Put it down when you need to. Come back.

CHAPTER ONE: WHAT IT ACTUALLY IS

Emotional abuse is the slow, repeated rearranging of your reality until you no longer trust your own version of it.

It doesn't announce itself. It rarely arrives as screaming. More often it shows up as a tone, a sigh, a withdrawal of warmth so precise you'd swear it was surgical. It's the relationship where you're always slightly off-balance, always apologizing for something you can't quite locate, always working to get back to a baseline of okay that keeps moving.

Here's what it tends to include, and you don't need all of them to count:

- **Criticism dressed as honesty.** "I'm just telling you the truth, nobody else will." The truth, somehow, is always that you're failing.
- **The shifting target.** You do the thing they asked. It's now the wrong thing. You can't win because winning was never available.
- **Contempt.** Eye-rolls, mimicry, the small theatrical disgust at who you are. Contempt is the one that does the deepest damage, because it tells you that your existence is irritating.
- **Withdrawal as punishment.** Silence used as a weapon. Affection rationed to keep you obedient.
- **Rewriting events.** "That never happened." "You're remembering it wrong." "You're so dramatic." Said long enough, you start to agree.

The mechanism underneath all of it is control through confusion. A confused person is easy to manage. A confused person doesn't leave, because she's not even sure there's anything to leave.

If you read that list and your stomach dropped — not because it was unfamiliar, but because it was *too* familiar — that's information. Sit with it. You're not being dramatic. You're being accurate, possibly for the first time in a long time.

CHAPTER TWO: WHY YOU STAYED QUIET

People who haven't lived it love to ask the question that isn't really a question: *Why didn't you say something?*

Let me answer it, because it deserves a real answer.

You stayed quiet because the abuse taught you that speaking up made it worse. Every time you raised it, the conversation became about your tone, your timing, your unreasonableness — never the thing itself. You learned. Silence wasn't weakness. Silence was a survival strategy that worked, until it stopped working.

You stayed quiet because you loved them. Because the same person who hurt you was also, sometimes, the person who knew you best. Because abuse rarely comes from monsters — it comes from people you chose, people with charm, people other people adore.

You stayed quiet because you didn't have the words. There's no bruise to point to. How do you explain a feeling? How do you tell your friend, *I feel like I'm slowly disappearing*, without sounding like you've lost it?

And you stayed quiet because, somewhere along the way, you started to believe it might be your fault. That if you were just a little easier, a little better, a little less *you*, none of this would be happening.

“

Silence is not consent. Silence is what survival looks like when speaking has been made dangerous.

Forgive the version of you who stayed quiet. She wasn't weak. She was holding the whole thing together with both hands so it wouldn't fall on the people she loved. That takes a strength most people never have to find.

CHAPTER THREE: THE BODY KEEPS A RECORD

Your mind can be talked out of almost anything. Your body cannot.

You can tell yourself the relationship is fine while your shoulders live up around your ears. You can insist you're not afraid while your heart rate spikes at the sound of a key in the door. The body keeps a record even when the mind has agreed to look away.

Pay attention to the physical tells, because they're often telling the truth before you're ready to:

- The flinch at a notification.
- The held breath when they walk in, while you read the weather of their mood.
- The way you relax — actually exhale — only when they leave the house.
- The exhaustion that no amount of sleep touches.

This is what living in low-grade threat does. Your nervous system never gets the all-clear, so it stays braced. Over months and years, that bracing becomes who you think you are. You call it anxiety. You call it being high-strung. Often it's just a body that's been standing guard for too long.

I want you to start treating your body's signals as evidence rather than embarrassment. When your stomach knots, that's not irrationality. That's a witness. It's been taking notes this whole time, faithfully, while you were busy explaining everything away.

Listen to the witness.

CHAPTER FOUR: A POEM FOR THE MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT

Some things won't fit into a paragraph. Here's one of them.

“

Inventory

>

“

*I kept the receipts of my own undoing—
the small concessions, the swallowed sentences,

the nights I made myself smaller

so the room would stay calm.*

>

“

I called it love. I called it patience.

I called it anything but the truth,

which was this:

I was being erased one apology at a time,

and I was holding the pen.

>

“

But a pen can write its way back.

Watch me.

If you read that and recognized yourself, you're not alone in the dark. There are more of us than you'd ever guess — people who learned to make themselves small and are now, slowly, taking up space again.

The last two lines matter most. The same hand that signed away pieces of you is the hand that writes the next part. That's not a metaphor I'm reaching for. It's the actual work of the chapters ahead.

CHAPTER FIVE: GASLIGHTING AND THE THEFT OF REALITY

Of everything emotional abuse does, this is the one that lingers longest: it steals your confidence in your own perception.

Gaslighting isn't just lying. It's lying *about your experience of reality* until you defer to someone else's account of your own life. You remember a conversation one way; you're told it went another way, with such certainty, such wounded conviction, that you start to think — maybe I really am confused. Maybe I really did overreact. Maybe I really am the problem.

Do this enough times and you outsource your reality. You stop trusting your memory, your read on a room, your gut. You check in with the abuser to find out what's true. Which is, of course, the entire point. A person who can't trust her own mind is fully dependent on whoever's narrating it.

Here's how you start taking it back:

Write things down as they happen. Not for court. For you. A plain record of what was said and done, before anyone gets the chance to revise it. When you're later told *that never happened*, you'll have your own account to stand on.

Notice the phrases. "You're too sensitive." "You're crazy." "You always do this." "I never said that." These are tools. Once you can name the tool, it loses some of its power over you.

Find one outside witness. A friend, a therapist, a sibling — someone who knew you before, who can reflect back the real you. You'll need that mirror, because the one at home has been warped on purpose.

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The goal of gaslighting is to make you a stranger to yourself. The cure begins the moment you choose your own account over theirs — even once, even quietly.

CHAPTER SIX: THE GRIEF NOBODY WARNS YOU ABOUT

When you finally name it, leave it, or simply start to wake up — you expect to feel free. Often what comes first is grief, and nobody warns you about it.

You grieve the person you thought they were. You grieve the future you'd built in your head. You grieve the years. You grieve, strangely, the abuser themselves — the good days were real too, and missing them doesn't make you broken. It makes you human.

And there's a stranger grief underneath all of it: grief for the version of yourself you might have been if you hadn't spent so long surviving. The confidence that never got to grow. The dreams you set down to keep the peace. The ease other people seem to carry that you had to trade away.

Let yourself grieve all of it. The grief is not a sign you made a mistake by leaving or waking up. The grief is the bill coming due for everything that was taken — and feeling it is how you stop carrying it.

You're allowed to miss something and still know you were right to walk away from it. Both things are true. Most true things come in pairs like that.

CHAPTER SEVEN: THE REWRITE FRAMEWORK

This is the heart of the book. Emotional abuse is, at its core, a story imposed on you — a story in which you are too much, not enough, the problem, the difficult one. Healing is not forgetting that story. It's rewriting it, line by line, in your own hand.

I call it **The Rewrite**. Five movements. Work through them with a notebook, slowly, over weeks if you need.

1. Name the Story You Were Given

Write down, in plain words, the story you were taught to believe about yourself. Be brutal and specific. *I am too sensitive. I'm hard to love. I ruin things. I can't trust my own judgment.* Get it out of your body and onto the page where you can see it. A story loses power when it's no longer narrating from the shadows.

2. Find the Author

Next to each line, write who taught it to you. Whose voice is that, actually? You'll find that almost none of these beliefs are yours. They were installed. *"I'm too sensitive"* — said in whose tone? You're not deleting your beliefs. You're returning them to sender.

3. Cross-Examine

Take each belief to trial. Where's the evidence? What's the evidence against it? "I ruin things" — name three things you've built, tended, kept alive. The abusive story relies on you never checking its claims. Check them. Most collapse on contact with the facts.

4. Write the True Line

For each false story, write the truer version. Not aspirational fluff — true. Not *I am a confident goddess* if that's not yet real. Something like: *I feel deeply, and that's a strength I was punished for. I made good decisions in an impossible situation. My judgment is sound; it was sabotaged, not absent.* Write the true line until it stops feeling like a lie. That can take a while. Keep writing it.

5. Live One Line Forward

Pick a single true line. Live one day as if it's already settled fact. If the line is *my judgment is sound*, make one decision today without seeking permission, then sit with the discomfort and notice the world doesn't end. Identity isn't rebuilt in revelation. It's rebuilt in repetitions small enough that fear can't stop them.

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You did not write the first draft of who you are. But you are holding the pen now, and the rest of the book is yours.

Do these in order. Repeat as needed. This isn't a one-time exercise — it's a practice you return to whenever the old story tries to take the narration back.

CHAPTER EIGHT: BECOMING SOMEONE NEW (WHO IS ALSO JUST YOU)

Here's the part that surprises people: rebuilding after emotional abuse isn't about becoming a brand-new person. It's about excavating the one who was there before they buried her.

She's not gone. She's underneath. All the smallness, the apology, the bracing — that's a costume you were made to wear. Take it off slowly. You'll feel exposed at first. That's normal. You've been armored so long that being soft feels like being in danger. It isn't. Not anymore.

Watch for the signs you're coming back:

- You catch yourself with an opinion you didn't run past anyone.
- You feel anger — clean, appropriate anger — instead of just guilt.
- You laugh at something and it's your real laugh, the loud one.
- You make a plan that's only for you.
- You stop explaining yourself to people who were always going to misread you anyway.

These are the green shoots. Protect them. Some of them are so small you'll be tempted to dismiss them — a moment of ease, a flash of certainty, a no said without a paragraph of apology behind it. Don't dismiss them. They are the comeback, arriving in installments.

The world will keep trying to hand you the old story; people who liked you smaller will prefer you small. They'll call your recovery a personality change, your boundaries coldness, your clarity bitterness. Let them be uncomfortable. Their comfort cost you

years.

You were misread, underestimated, rewritten by someone who needed you confused to keep you close. That chapter is over. The pen is in your hand. And the most radical thing you can write next is a life where you are believed — starting with believing yourself.

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The bruise was invisible. Your recovery doesn't have to be. Live loud enough that the version of you who suffered in silence can finally hear that she made it out.

KEEP GOING

You don't have to do the rebuilding alone, and you don't have to do it all at once.

If this book met you somewhere real, the work continues in **The Reinvention Workbook** — a guided writing companion for people in the middle of becoming someone new. It picks up exactly where *The Rewrite* leaves off.

Come find more at **mkparrish.com**, where I write about identity, voice, reinvention, and the long work of taking your story back.

You were never the problem. You were the one holding everything together. Now hold something for yourself.

— MK Parrish

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